

**The Adventures
of Luke
Friends & Foes
Book 1**

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Prologue

Luke woke up. The sounds of birds chirping and cars driving outside his house sounded the same as they always did. He got out of bed, changed out of his pajamas and headed out into the kitchen, not bothering to fix his hair or make his bed. He poured cereal and milk into a bowl and ate it slowly as he turned on the TV to see the news.

Nothing new came on. The stories were the same old stuff they talked about all day, everyday. He turned it off, longing for something interesting in his life to happen one day. Everyday felt the same. He woke up, went to work, and came back home. There was the occasional extra stuff like running errands and hanging out with friends, even though he only had a few. He tried to find new things to do, hobbies to get into, but nothing really stuck with him.

He hadn't found anything that interested him and he knew he must be a special case since nothing felt right for him. After he finished his cereal he put the bowl

in the sink, leaving the task of cleaning it for his future self. As he walked over to the bathroom, he got a great idea: Camping!

It had been a while since he'd gone out into the forest and tried living in the wilderness. He enjoyed nature and loved a little bit of adventure, even though there wasn't much adventure to be found in his day-to-day life. It would be good for him, he thought. He would have a great time and maybe learn something new while he was at it.

He sent a message to his boss asking for the rest of the week off for his trip. Fortunately, his boss agreed. Luke thanked him and started getting ready for the journey ahead of him. He seemed to be hyping up camping more than necessary, he knew he would enjoy it anyway. As long as he wasn't just sitting around and spending his time in the tent, it was going to be worth it.

He asked some friends if they wanted to come along since he thought he might get a bit bored without any company, but none of them were able to find time for it. So, he was left to go by himself. He could still find

some fun in it, even without friends. He started to pack up, planning to head out in the morning.

Chapter 1

The Forest

The next day he woke up excited for the trip he was going on. He grabbed his stuff, all of it ready and well-packed from yesterday. After carefully fitting it into his small car, he got into the front seat and drove off to the forest. After about an hour of driving, he finally arrived and found a nice area to unpack in. The forest was quiet, calm, and very refreshing. It was pretty chilly out since he'd decided to come out near the end of winter. The trees were beginning to grow their leaves back, and they provided some shade, partially blocking the sun's bright glow.

Once he got his tent and some other extra utilities set up, he decided to get a fire ready. He hadn't brought fire wood and although he had an axe, he wasn't very educated in how to use it properly. He thought he could find some lying around instead. Luke started walking away from his campsite with only his pocket knife. As

he walked, the forest slowly started to grow darker and more frightening. The farther from his camp he was, the more unsettling the forest got.

He had a strange feeling that he didn't like it one bit. It seemed like there were endless trees for miles. Luckily, the path he followed slowly led him downhill into a more open area with most of the trees absent. Bushes surrounded the area and only one small opening would allow him to squeeze past them and trek deeper into the woods. But before he did, a small rustling sound came from the bushes. Luke quickly turned towards the source of the sound, pulling out his pocket knife in fear.

He backed up a bit as the sounds grew closer and the bushes started to shake softly. Slowly, a husky puppy crept its way out, stopping when it saw Luke. Its eyes were filled with fear, doubt, and longing. It seemed to beg to Luke, silently asking him to help with just the look in its eyes alone. It was very small and young. There was no one nearby. He wasn't near a public campsite and didn't think anyone else was camping here. He was baffled by the thought of this puppy having found its way all the way out here by accident. Luke

pushed the thought aside and slowly gestured for it to come to him.

To his surprise, it walked slowly to him and cuddled up against him. He pulled it up onto his lap, sitting with it for a moment before getting back up. The puppy jumped out of his lap and stood next to him, waiting for him to lead the way. Luke wasn't sure what to do and he didn't know if he should keep the puppy. He wasn't sure if he was fit to raise a dog but decided to help for now. He kept walking, making his way out of the bush surrounded area and pressing further into the forest.

He soon found some trees that had been chopped down or somehow destroyed, since they were all on the ground with most of the bark ripped off them. He picked up the large pieces of the logs and some smaller sticks, already forming a picture of the campfire in his mind.

The puppy picked up a stick of its own and was playing with it. Luke decided to name it, so he had something to call it. He thought for a moment, not sure what to call him. But soon enough he decided on a good name.

“Hey, would you be okay if I called you Leo?” he asked the puppy. Leo seemed to agree, sticking out his tongue and wagging his tail.

“Okay then, I hope you like it,” he added.

He turned back, ready to return to his campsite. However, when he looked around, he realized he didn’t know where he had come from. He decided to start walking anyway, hoping he would find the bushes where he had found Leo and know his way back from there. He didn’t. He only led himself further into his lost state. He started to panic, the regret of not paying more attention stabbing into him like a knife. He took a turn, hoping it would help. He kept making more and more turns, but he had no sense of direction anymore. He pulled out his phone hoping he could get at least one bar of data, but to no avail.

In his craze, he hadn’t noticed Leo’s silent attempts to try and get him to stop walking. He tugged at his pants and whimpered softly. Luke kept walking though, finding himself in an oddly open area where a large grizzly bear slept soundly in a dark cave just 20 yards away. Luke quickly stopped, his footsteps coming

to a halt as he looked up from his phone and slowly put it in his pocket. He stared at the bear, his eyes wide.

He was way closer to it than he should have been, and any sudden movement could wake it and put him in a lot of trouble. He took one slow step back but unfortunately stepped on a twig. It snapped, waking the bear from its slumber. It slowly rose and opened its eyes. It looked at Luke and roared ferociously as it started to chase him. Luke turned and started to run as fast as possible, passing by Leo who had been watching in

the distance. Leo started to run with Luke, keeping up with him easily as he ran. The bear continued to chase them as it growled murderously.

Luke started to head up a small mountain, trying to lose the bear as he climbed some rocks. Leo had struggled to follow, and Luke had to quickly grab him and help him up. The bear started to climb and was getting closer with every second. Luke got to the top, panting and breathing heavily as he looked back at the bear who was gaining on him. He kept running, using as much strength and energy as he could to get as far away as possible, but the bear kept coming. It had gotten to the

top too and was running faster than Luke now. His legs started to get tired as he looked back at the bear, and he started to lose hope.

He looked for Leo, who was now gone. His only friend had seemed to betray him out of fear. He turned to look where he was going and quickly stopped, nearly having run right off of a steep cliff. Sharp rocks stared at him from below as he looked down. He slowly turned back to the bear, his fate sealed. The bear had slowed down, wanting to make sure his prey couldn't run anymore.

Luke stared at the bear, his mind boggled with thoughts, leaving him with nothing as he stood there frozen with fear. The bear inched closer with every passing second, and Luke knew this was the end. Just as it seemed like he was betrayed and left to die, he noticed a small movement out of the corner of his eye. Leo had been sneaking towards the bear, his lip curled as he got ready to attack. The bear was oblivious and Luke was at the very edge of the cliff, waiting to see Leo's next move.

Leo jumped forward, opening his jaws and biting down as hard as he could on the bear's hind leg. It fell to the ground in pain, unable to move from the injury. Luke quickly ran past the bear, relief flooding over him as he passed the large, bulky creature. Leo followed him, and they both quickly made their way down the mountain and to a safer area.

Luke stopped running once he was far away from the bear, and sat up against a tree to rest. He was exhausted from the chase, and his heart was pounding from the fear he had faced. Leo walked up to him, looking only half as scared as Luke was. Luke looked at Leo, his eyes full of gratitude for his new friend that had saved him from the beast.

"Thank you so much, Leo. I would be dead without you coming to save me," Luke said as he lifted his hand to start giving Leo soft pets.

Leo wagged his tail, taking pride in his action as he sat and enjoyed the pets. Luke continued petting him for a few more moments before getting back up.

"We better find our way back soon. We're lucky we survived that and I don't want to risk being out here

longer,” Luke said to Leo, even though he wasn’t sure Leo would understand what he was saying. Suddenly, Leo’s head jerked to the side, staring intently at something. Luke followed his gaze and spotted red, glowing eyes. There was a shadowy figure standing there, half hidden by a tree. He squinted a bit to get a better look, but the figure was gone.

Leo started barking and ran off towards the spot it was standing in. Luke watched for a moment, expecting him to stop once he got there. However, Leo kept running and disappeared from sight as he got further away. Luke started to run after him, calling out his name to get him to come back but Leo was long gone. He stopped running and stood there, hoping he would come back. He began to hear a soft noise coming from far away. It sounded like something spinning, almost like helicopter blades.

Leo burst through the bushes, disrupting Luke’s thoughts. He started barking and jumping onto Luke, trying to get him to follow him. Leo ran off again and Luke followed, hoping he had found something. The noise grew louder as he followed Leo, and soon enough

he walked out into a large clearing. A large shiny figure came into view. It was a helicopter! The flying machine was huge and black with a large symbol on the side which represented it as a rescue vehicle. Luke let out a long sigh of relief as he walked up to the helicopter.

A tall, big burly man with a long red beard and camo clothing got out of the helicopter and shouted, “Well, you seem to be lost. You want a ride?”

“Yes please,” replied Luke. He climbed inside with Leo and sat in a seat before all three of them took off.

“That dog of yours is a life saver you know,” the man said.

“Yeah, I think I’ll keep him for a long, long time,” replied Luke.

They flew for a while and found Luke’s campsite. The man dropped him off nearby before leaving. Luke made sure to thank the man before he left. As Luke walked up to his campsite, he decided that camping might not be his thing. In the end, he slowly packed up, got into his car and let Leo take a nap in the passenger seat during the drive. As he drove, he decided

if he was ever going to go camping again, he was definitely going to bring a compass.

Chapter 2

The Plane Ride

A couple weeks after Luke got back home, his friend asked if he wanted to go on a trip with him. It was Tyson asking, one of the friends he'd had since 1st grade. They would be going to some tropical islands off the coast of Torno, their hometown. It seemed like fun, and although Luke could barely afford it, he was all in. He needed some rest from the scarring experience in the forest he had had not long ago. Luckily, most of the money that would pay for the trip came from Tyson's parents. His parents had always been quite wealthy, and it usually was a great perk of being Tyson's friend.

Even though the two were best friends, they were actually quite different. They were both 20 and enjoyed wearing mostly t-shirts; but other than that, they had a number of small differences. Tyson usually was a lot more laid-back and played tons of video games. He wore basketball shorts and spent most of his time just enjoying

life. Luke, on the other hand, spent most of his time studying and working on other things that would help lead him to a successful future. He didn't play games much and was a lot more outgoing than Tyson at times.

Despite their differences, they were still great friends and shared many common interests. They would hang out a ton and Tyson could usually get Luke to play some video games from time to time. Once they had planned the trip—the flight, hotel room, food, and more—they were ready to go.

They met up at the airport, made their way through security speedily, and were soon sitting patiently at the gate as they waited for boarding. The airport was bustling with activity and there were tons of people speed-walking down the long halls as they made their way to the gates. The small shops on the side all looked very enticing, and Luke desperately wanted to go get snacks, a neck pillow, or something else he'd enjoy. The large windows showed the planes taking off and coming in for landing. The entire intricate process of departures and landings without any mistakes fascinated Luke. Tyson however, sat there on his phone, staring at the

screen as he was grossly immersed in the game he was playing.

Luke noticed his state and tried to pull him away from it, “So, why did you want to go on this trip? You never really get out much so I’m kind of surprised you invited me in the first place,” Luke teased.

Tyson seemed to pull himself away from the game, pausing it and looking towards Luke, not pleased by the comment. “Well, I thought I should get out and have some fun with my friend. It’s gonna be great, and I’ve got a ton of stuff planned for us to do,” Tyson said.

“Sounds fun. I’m glad you invited me. I need some time to rest and take it easy. I had a rough time camping not too long ago,” Luke said, piquing Tyson’s attention.

“You went camping? What happened?” he asked curiously.

“I got lost when I went looking for firewood. I ended up finding a dog that I named Leo and I now own him. And I ended up running into a bear which almost killed me... It was a whole thing.”

Tyson listened intently, his mind seeming to form more questions. “Wow, that sounds rough. Why didn’t you tell me this sooner? And you have a dog now? That doesn’t sound like you,” Tyson pointed out.

“I wasn’t sure if it was worth telling. And yeah, I never expected to have a dog either, but he did save me from the bear. I’d be dead if he didn’t help,” Luke said, before continuing, “And he was lost and I didn’t know where he had come from, so I decided to keep him.”

“He didn’t have a collar or anything?” Tyson asked.

“Nope, nothing,” Luke answered.

“Well, good luck I guess. Hope that was a good choice,” Tyson said, half jokingly.

“Yeah, paying for it may be a bit of a problem, but I should be fine,” Luke said confidently.

“Well, if you need any help, just give me a call,” Tyson offered.

“Good to know. Thanks.” Luke silently sighed with relief before continuing the conversation, “So how’s life been for you? It’s been a bit since we’ve talked. What’s happened since?”

“Oh, you know me, not much. Just been gaming most of the time. I did get a job though, since my parents were sick of me living with them still. I’m moving out soon, luckily.”

“Nice, where do you work?” Luke asked.

“Just a small restaurant near my house, nothing much really...” Tyson replied.

“Got it. I have to stop by sometime, don’t I?”
Luke said with a smirk.

“You could if you want, but I’m not there much. I only work two days a week,” Tyson said.

“I might stop by then. Depends on how I’m doing,” Luke concluded.

A woman’s voice sounded on the speaker, telling them that they were boarding now.

“That’s us, we should get going,” Tyson said, getting out of his chair.

Luke stood up, grabbing his stuff while replying, “Yep. It’s gonna be quite a long flight, right?” He asked.

“Yeah, about four hours. Hope you’re ready,”
Tyson grinned.

“I’m ready, I’ll probably just listen to music or something,” Luke replied nonchalantly.

“I’m gonna play my game most of the time,” Tyson said.

“You’re always playing it; what’s so fun about it anyway?” Luke asked, instantly regretting it as Tyson started to go on a rant about the mechanics of the game.

Luckily they boarded the plane and Tyson stopped. They both made their way to the seats and got comfortable. Tyson pulled out his phone, and Luke put on his headphones, both of them plunging into a different reality as they sat in silence for a while.

After about two hours, Tyson got up to head to the bathroom. Luke sat there, having pulled out a book to start reading. The flight had been quite uneventful and he started getting quite bored. He knew Tyson was probably going to do tons of crazy stuff when they got there. They’d probably be all over the place, doing stuff from surfing to winning a pie eating competition (something that Tyson had done multiple times). He was sure he was going to have fun with him; he just knew he would get

tired far before Tyson did. He kept reading, focusing on the book more than his thoughts. He could figure that out later.

Once he had read a few more pages, he started to get bored again. He put his headphones back on and started watching a movie on his phone. He fully lost track of time, not even realizing Tyson's overdue absence. It had been about twenty minutes, and as Luke started to look around, he noticed the chaos around him. He pulled off his headphones and heard people in agony. Many were yelling and babies were crying. Luke put his stuff down and stood up, looking for both Tyson and the source of the panic around him.

People were running around as the plane started to shake. Luke walked out into the aisle and slowly made his way to the captain's room as he decided to take action. He pushed through the crowds of people and got to the door, which he banged on, trying to get someone's attention. "What's going on in there?!" he yelled. He started to kick the door, no answer came. He put all his strength into one last kick. The door flew down with a thud as it bursted out of the wall. The room was dark,

and there was a sudden chill as he walked in. He looked around, trying to find the captain, but couldn't see. He pulled his phone out to turn on a light.

BOOM!

An explosion jerked the plane to the right, causing Luke to drop his phone. He fell to the floor and slid against it before hitting the wall. He scrambled back up, snatching his phone before running out the door and looking around to see what had happened. The passengers were freaking out even more now, most of them helpless at this point. He ran to the nearest window and could see the right wing of the plane burning into pieces. The plane started to fall at a slow rate towards the deep sea down below. He decided to try and open the doors on the side of the plane but both of them were locked.

As he was trying to open one of the doors, he heard a low hissing sound. He turned around and saw multiple snakes staring at him, each one ready to strike. He ran to the right and down the aisle, the snakes following him. The passengers moved out of the way, but the snakes only seemed to be after him. He ran into

the bathroom at the back of the plane to hide. He sat there thinking about what to do. His mind slowly drifted back to Tyson since he still didn't know if he was okay or not. Then he had an idea. There must be a button in the cockpit that would unlock the side doors.

He quickly got to work, slowly opening the bathroom door and peered outside. No snakes. He ran across the plane to the cockpit, pushing the other passengers out of the way. The door was shut again, but he was able to get it open with a forceful push. He heard loud thumps behind him and looked back. The snakes were attacking the passengers. His eyes widened at the scene, but he tried to focus. He ran into the cockpit and slammed the door shut.

He looked around the room. It was still too dark to see anything, so he pulled out his phone and turned the flashlight on. He used the light to look around the cockpit and after some searching, he found a button that would open the doors. He pressed the button and turned back to the door. A black figure stood in front of the door, the phone's light seeming to fade into the shadow as it reached the humanoid. Red eyes stared at him as he

examined them. They were the same he had seen in the forest.

“Who are you!?” Luke asked in a stern voice.

“Your worst nightmare...” A voice called back. The figure had disappeared, but still spoke, “Go on, save yourself while you still can...”

He ran out of the cockpit, deciding to listen to the voice's instructions since he didn't know what else to do. He ran up to the door, quickly threw it open, and almost was sucked out from the wind flying past. The plane was about 50 feet above the ocean, and Luke didn't have anywhere else to go. He looked back down the aisle bodies littered the floor as the snakes slithered around.

Tyson was nowhere to be seen. He hoped he was okay, but it was too dangerous to stay and look. Luke looked back out of the plane, seeing an island far off in the distance in the direction the plane was heading. It kept gliding down towards the ocean, and just before it plunged into the water, Luke jumped out.

Chapter 3

Stranded

The plane wing rushed past him and the rest of it flew into the water, sinking down quickly. Luke hit the surface of the water hard, knocking the air out of him. He started to drown a bit, unable to swim in his state, but soon snapped back, having caught his breath. He looked towards the island and started to swim. Thoughts raced through his head, but most were pushed aside as he focused on swimming back to land first. His arms grew tired as he got closer to the sandy shores. He crawled on to the island, laying down in the sand and panting like a dog.

As he caught his breath, he started to consider everything that just happened. It was one of the craziest things that had ever happened to him, and he still didn't know what had happened to Tyson. He felt like crying after everything that had happened. It was a lot for him and he was sure he had lost one of his best friends. But

he stayed calm, telling himself that Tyson would be alright. He never saw him, not even his body, so he might have gotten off the plane somehow. It was unlikely, but he had to stay composed somehow.

He stood up and looked around the island. A large mountain shaped like a volcano loomed over the island giving Luke a sense of dread. He spotted a small cave that could barely be seen from his angle. Along the long coast line, there were lots of trees that had bananas and coconuts. The rest of the island was a large jungle, and he could see a treehouse nearby. He walked over to the treehouse to start exploring.

He found some stuff inside, including a flashlight which surprisingly worked, some food, and a note. The note was quite ominous, and didn't give much context,

*I've been stuck on this island for weeks. If you're reading this, you likely ended up here like me and don't know what to do. As far as I know, be careful on this island and don't trust anything **he** says.*

Luke didn't know who 'he' was, but decided to keep the information in mind. He also decided to stay in the treehouse for the night since it was getting late. He

would try to find a way off the island tomorrow, but for now he needed rest.

He woke up, unsure of what time it was. His phone was broken and couldn't be used, so he was on his own at that point. He decided to hike up the mountain so he could get a view from up high. Maybe there was another island nearby or maybe he could signal a rescue helicopter of some kind. He started his climb up the large mountain, having brought some food with him. He slowly trekked on through trees and vines, the overgrown forest making it very hard to keep going. It was quite uneventful, and he found no signs of life anywhere on the island

Upon reaching the top of the mountain, Luke noticed that it had a large hole in the top but nothing inside, proving his theory of it being a volcano. Fortunately, it was a dormant one. As he looked around, he saw another note. He picked it up. It was longer than the last and contained a lot more information about the island.

*I've noticed that no planes nor helicopters ever fly past here. It's been a couple of weeks and there's been nothing. I keep seeing this dark figure staring at me from a distance. I know **he's** trying to get something out of me, I'm just not sure what. If you see this, I hope you get off this island because I don't think I will...*

Luke read it, wondering if the dark figure was the same one he's been seeing. *Maybe all of this isn't just by coincidence*, he thought. He didn't know who it was, or what they wanted, but something was doing this, and they had been doing it since the forest. Luke decided to explore the cave. It was the last thing that stuck out to him, and maybe there was something in it. He went back down the mountain. The hike going down was as bad as the one going up. He walked up to the cave which was pitch black and sunk down into the earth.

Luckily he had the flashlight he found yesterday, and it was still working. He turned it on and cautiously walked down into the cave. The light was dim but he was able to see what was in front of him. There were mostly just rocks and some stalagmites. He could hear water dripping in the distance. A bat flew by, startling

him as he tried to make sure it didn't bite him. Once it was gone, he kept walking and soon came up to a large door. It had runes on it; they looked like viking symbols, but he couldn't interpret them. He slid his hand across the door, but nothing happened. He tried to push it open, but it wouldn't budge. Soon enough, he left and made his way out of the cave.

As he came out of the cave, he noticed some clouds forming in the sky. It was getting darker outside, possibly signalling rain. He headed back into the forest to look around a bit more, staying closer to the coast this time. Once he had made his way around most of the island, he found something. He was on the opposite side of the island from where he had landed. There were some ruins, mostly grown over by the jungle but still intact. He walked into a temple which had tons of runes that looked similar to the ones on the door in the cave.

He soon found a room that had five buttons, and they looked identical to the ones on the door. He placed his hand on one and they seemed loose. He softly pressed on one and it sunk into the wall a bit. However, it just popped back out after he pressed it. He pressed the

other ones and they did the same except for one of them which stayed in the wall. He pressed another button and it popped out, bringing the pressed one back up too. *Do I have to press them in the correct order?* he thought. He kept pressing them, slowly learning the pattern through trial and error. Once he got it and all the buttons were pressed in the correct order, the eyes on a statue lit up above him. He walked out of the temple, wondering if the door had opened.

As he was walking back, he saw the shadowy figure out of the corner of his eyes stalking him from afar. He looked over, staring the red eyes down. The humanoid slowly walked out of the shady trees and up to Luke, stopping a few feet in front of him.

“What do you want with me?” Luke asked, showing no fear of the figure.

“You’ll find out soon enough,” he said ominously.

“Who are you!? I’m done with these games! Let me go! I want to go home!” Luke revolted.

“Calm down, this will be over soon...” The figure disappeared again and the island began to shake

violently. A loud explosion turned Luke's attention towards the top of the mountain. Large fireballs were flying out left and right, and lava started to spew out the top. Luke started to run, large magma rocks crashing down into the jungle near him. He could feel the heat of them even from how far away he was. He kept running along the coastline looking for the cave. Some of the rocks flew into the ocean, sizzling as they slowly fell into the depths of the blue mass of water. The lava had started to burn the island as it poured out. More rocks started to fly out, tearing the jungle apart.

At last Luke spotted the cave and ran inside, turning on his flashlight. He ran up to the door which was open now. He ran into the small room that was behind the door. There was nothing inside except for a small metal trapdoor on the floor that he couldn't open. He tried to head out of the cave the other way, but the lava had started to pour in. He ran back, trying to pry open the trapdoor, but to no avail.

He desperately looked around and noticed a small lever on the wall that he hadn't seen before. He ran up to it and pulled it down. The trapdoor flew open and

Luke walked up to it. There was a ladder, which he quickly climbed down to escape the lava. Once he got to the bottom, there was a long hallway filled with human skeletons. He disturbingly walked through, looking around and wondering where they had come from. There was nothing but the skeletons, and each of them looked rotten and dirty. He kept walking, soon coming to a large room. There were no lights, and the flashlight had stopped working without warning. He looked around, but couldn't see anything.

The lights suddenly flashed on, and Luke saw a man sitting in a chair at the end of the room. He looked exactly like the shadow humanoid, but was not a shadow anymore. He looked up at Luke. He had a neatly chiseled face and a well-built body. He was tall, had black hair, and green, slightly glowing eyes. He wore a neat outfit, a red suit that covered most of his skin. He wore nice white gloves and had sleek brown shoes on. He stood up and spoke, "Hello, Luke."

Chapter 4

Imprisoned

Luke looked at the man, not knowing how to reply. He looked around the room: It looked like the interior of a castle, having stone walls and red banners with a strange symbol hanging from the top. A long red carpet was rolled out, reaching from Luke to the chair the man was sitting in. Large quartz pillars lined the room, and there were a few doors on the side that led to other rooms.

After taking in his surroundings, he answered, “How do you know my name?”

“I have my ways, but that shouldn’t concern you right now. You should be much more worried about what’s going to happen to you,” the man said menacingly.

“W-what do you mean?” Luke asked slowly, ready to start running.

“I am not who you think I am. There is much more going on than you think. I’ve been... collecting people. I guess you could say that. Let’s just say, after today you’ll be working for me. I just need to run a few tests first.” Once the man had finished, he looked around, taking his eyes off Luke for just a moment. Luke had had enough and decided to make a run for it.

“Where do you think you’re going!?” The man yelled as Luke ran into one of the many hallways. He quickly started to follow him, but Luke was long gone. Luke ran into another hallway and hid in a small room he found, quickly closing the door behind him. He heard the man running down the hallway outside the room. He backed up, fearing the man might check the room he was in.

As the footsteps trailed off, he peeked out the door and watched as the man turned into a large beast. He was made of black mist, like a giant shadow. He roared, shaking the entire place. Some rocks fell to the floor from the roof as he started sprinting around the castle, destroying the walls as he rushed through. Luke

opened the door slightly before making a run down the hallway in the opposite direction of the beast.

The halls were endless, and there were multiple floors too. He ran around, feeling more lost with every turn. The castle was a giant maze with no sign of an exit in sight.

“WHERE ARE YOU!?” Luke flinched at the loud yelling that had abruptly started. He heard something coming down the hallway and quickly ran the other way, looking for a room to hide in. He turned a corner, saw a door and quickly ran inside to avoid getting seen by the creature. As he sat inside, he heard the creature rush past and the room he was in shook.

“FINE! IS THAT HOW YOU WANT TO PLAY?! THEN THAT’S HOW IT’LL BE.” Luke heard the booming voice from inside the room and could also hear multiple loud thumps outside. He peeked out the door and could see many large shadow creatures prowling the halls in search of him. He closed the door and looked around the room for something to help him. He walked around quietly, making sure not to draw attention to himself. He walked up to a small desk in the

center of the room and opened the drawers on it. They were all empty. Nothing else was in the room, and he knew he had to move to a new one.

He walked back to the door, opening it softly and peeking out. A large tiger-like creature was slowly walking down the hall away from him. He quietly walked out, heading the other way. Once he was far from it, he picked up the pace, speed walking down the hallways and looking for another room. He turned a corner, and a large shadow gorilla stared at him for a moment. Suddenly, it started running towards Luke, the floor thumping up and down as it threw itself towards Luke.

He tried to run, but the gorilla caught up to him, scooping him up in his large hands. The gorilla threw Luke up against a wall, knocking the air out of him. He fell to the floor, barely able to breathe. The large beast slowly started to transform back into the man. A few moments later he stood in front of Luke staring him down.

“I have to say, you put up a good fight there. Not many have tried that. But, I’m afraid you can’t escape

this time. I made the last few challenges easy. The forest, the plane ride, the island. All of it was me,” the man said, still keeping eye contact with Luke.

Luke opened his mouth to speak, but he was only able to gasp a few words out, “W-why? Why would you do this-?”

The man looked at Luke for a moment before answering, “I have my reasons. I need warriors to help defend my castle. Not this one, it’s merely a recreation. The real one is on an entirely different planet. You’ll see it soon, don’t worry.” Luke listened, wondering what he meant. *Was there alien life or something on different planets?* he wondered.

Suddenly the man spoke again, “Now, your tests will begin soon, but for now, I must keep you contained. You’ve proved yourself to be quite the trouble maker,” the man concluded. Luke looked up at the man, opening his mouth to speak. However, he didn’t get a single word out before the man kicked him in the face, knocking him out cold.

Luke woke up on a freezing stone floor. He looked around, realizing he was in a small prison cell. It had enough room to fit maybe five more people, and consisted of a bed, a sink, and a toilet. He got up and ran to the iron bars blocking him from escape, grabbing them and pulling on them out of anger. They didn't budge and Luke knew he wasn't getting out.

He walked over to the bed, sitting down on the flat, thin mattress, feeling hopeless. *Why him?* he wondered. He laid his head down on the pillow, feeling a hard object underneath. He lifted his head back up and moved the pillow, revealing a screwdriver underneath. He questioned how it got there and if he could use it. He answered one question instantly as he looked around the room, seeing a large vent above the sink. It was screwed shut, and Luke quickly jumped out of the bed and climbed up onto the sink and started unscrewing the vent. The large metal plate fell out into his hands, and he let it fall to the floor. The loud clanking of the metal caused him to freeze in place, wondering if anyone had heard it. After nothing came, he climbed into the vent.

The vent was quite dusty, and didn't look very safe to crawl through. It was also just big enough to fit in, meaning he would have to squeeze his way through most of it. He slowly crawled through, his body compacting to fit through it. He kept crawling and soon found another cell. He looked into the room through a vent of its own. Someone was sitting on the bed, their face looking down at the floor.

Luke immediately recognized who it was, and called out his name, "Tyson!" Tyson seemed to snap out of deep thought and looked around, wondering where the voice had come from.

"I'm up here in the vent! It's me, Luke!" he called out once more. Tyson looked up to the vent, a smile forming on his face and his eyes lighting up as he saw Luke.

"Luke! I'm so relieved to see you. I thought you were dead!" Tyson got off the bed and walked over to the vent.

"I thought you were dead! The plane we were on crashed and I never saw you get off. In fact, I thought I was the only one. Here, take this and climb up here."

Luke carefully pushed the screwdriver through the gap in the vent, and let it fall into Tyson's hands. Tyson took the screwdriver and unscrewed the vent with haste. He climbed up in and followed Luke as he continued crawling.

Luke looked back at Tyson, bringing his voice down to a whisper, "Make sure to be quiet, we can't let anyone know we're escaping."

"Got it," Tyson said while nodding softly. They both continued pressing through the vent, soon finding a room that wasn't a prison cell. It was like the office Luke had found earlier while running from the shadow figures.

They hopped down from the vent and quickly looked in the drawers. This room had two large wardrobes unlike the other room that had one desk. In each wardrobe there was a full set of armor. They looked identical, mostly made of a shiny steel with red and blue paint creating an intricate design on them. They both put on the armor. It was quite heavy at first, but they were able to adapt to it.

Inside Luke's wardrobe was a large sword with a light blue gem holding the base together. It was shiny

like armor, and had a similar design. It was extremely sharp, probably able to cut through anything with ease. He slowly lifted it off the rack it was placed on, and a surge of energy rushed through him. The sword made him feel powerful but he couldn't describe why. Tyson had grabbed a large bow from his wardrobe. It was heavy duty and looked very sleek. It came with a quiver, filled with tons of arrows. He strapped it to his back, and held the bow tight.

“Dang, this is some sick weaponry,” Tyson complimented.

“Yeah, I wonder why that dude left it here. No security either,” Luke pointed out.

“Yeah, strange-” A loud voice cut off Tyson, sounding through the entire castle, “WHERE DID THEY GO!? FIND THEM NOW!” It was the man that had captured them. Luke could hear heavy footsteps headed their way, and was prepared to fight.

“Looks like we’ve got company,” Tyson said.

“Yep, hopefully these can help,” Luke said, getting ready to walk out into the hallway. They ran out,

and turned towards the incoming enemies. Large shadow beasts ran at them, their teeth bared.

Luke swung at a large elephant that had attacked him. The sword sliced through it like butter, and the elephant faded away. More animals attacked him, but he was able to slice each of them with ease. Tyson was shooting from afar, getting used to the bow. He fired multiple shots in quick succession, taking creatures out left and right. Tons of smaller human-like figures started to run after them. They came in large numbers, and Luke had trouble getting them all.

Tyson kept shooting, missing some of the smaller targets. Luke started to feel a surge of power, and jumped up about five feet into the air, crashing the sword down onto a large crowd of enemies. A small shockwave was sent out by the blast, knocking many out. Most faded away, others were pushed down to the floor. Luke kept swinging, his swings getting larger and more accurate each time. Tyson started taking out some enemies that had begun to attack from behind. More large animals started attacking them, but they were able to easily take care of them.

A large crash turned their attention to a large beast that had fallen down through the roof. It was twice as large as the other ones and had some kind of plating around it, protecting it from any damage. Luke jumped up at it, swinging the sword onto the armor of it with great force. It cracked a bit but didn't break, and the large beast swatted Luke with its hand, sending him flying down the hallway. He rolled on the floor as he came to a halt.

Tyson had noticed and started shooting the beast, the arrows cracking the plates, but mostly just bouncing off it. He kept shooting as Luke got back up, quickly attacking the beast again. He dodged a large swing of its fist and quickly slid underneath it, slicing into the underbelly of the beast. There was no plating protecting the underside, and the beast cried out in pain as it fell to the floor and faded away.

Luke and Tyson regrouped, ready to be attacked again. Large metal thumps could be heard coming down the hall, and knights in metal armor turned the corner. They rushed towards Luke and Tyson, swinging their swords at them as they attacked. Luke swung at them,

destroying their armor with a powerful swing. Tyson kept shooting, somehow still equipped with arrows. The arrows pierced through the armor, damaging the knights. They kept attacking and soon got rid of all the knights.

Luke and Tyson stood next to each other, breathing heavily as they looked down the hallways for more enemies but none came. After a brief moment of silence, the man slowly walked out of a room, standing at the end of the hallway that Luke and Tyson were in.

“Well, well, well. You two have caused much more of a commotion than I had planned. I guess I’ll have to deal with you two myself then, won’t I? You might as well know who your captor is at this point.” The man paused for a moment before continuing, “My name is Xzavion. I am a special man who has been granted power by The Great Ones. I was supposed to help, and for the most part I have been. But recently I’ve been planning something—something big. I needed an army to protect myself while I worked in secret on my planet. I’m sure they already know, but they haven’t stopped me yet, and I’m done following their orders.”

Xzavion seemed to snap away from a thought and turned back to Luke and Tyson. “You two will make great warriors. I’m sure you’d be happy to help me, right?” Luke and Tyson looked at each other, each of them unwilling to help him.

“No, we won’t help you. Whatever you’re doing, it doesn’t seem good,” Luke replied.

“If you don’t help, you’ll be standing in my way. I plan to control the entire universe with this. And if you two won’t help, then I’ll have to get rid of you one way or another,” Xzavion threatened.

“Fine, it can be that way, but we won’t go down easily,” Tyson said, siding with Luke.

“Yeah, we’re both done with you. It’s time we end this,” Luke said, suggesting a fight between them.

“Then a fight it shall be. I won’t go easy on you two. I plan to get rid of you both, since neither of you want to help me,” Xzavion said, planning to keep that promise, “I’ll give you both a few minutes to get ready. I’ll see you on the battlefield.” Xzavion suddenly disappeared, leaving the two to talk to each other.

“Are you sure we can take this guy? He seems really powerful. And we’ve never really fought before...” Tyson said.

“I’m sure we’ll be fine. We handled those monsters easily, and we make a great team,” Luke said, sparking a bit more hope in Tyson. Tyson nodded, seeming a bit more confident now.

“Okay then, I hope you’re right. But I guess it’s our only way of getting out of here,” Tyson pointed out.

“Yeah, so we better make sure we win this. Or... we’ll probably be dead...” Luke gravely commented.

“Yeah, let’s be careful here. We have to make sure we make no mistakes. We may outnumber him, but he overpowers us, so we have to use everything we’ve got,” Tyson said.

“Yep. Now, where is he?” Luke said, looking around. Xzavion flashed into view through some kind of rift. “Follow me.”

Luke and Tyson looked at each other, and nodded before following him. Neither spoke, not knowing what to say.

“I hope you’ve gotten used to those weapons and that armor.” Xzavion said, until muttering under his breath, “*That you stole...*”

Luke chuckled at his last comment, but didn’t say anything. Xzavion scoffed and led them to a large elevator.

“Well, I’ll meet you down there. Good luck to you both,” Xzavion said as he pressed the button to open the elevator.

Luke and Tyson walked in, sealing their fates. The elevator started to clank down the shaft, the windows revealing a large battle field surrounded by lava. There was a large opening in the top, indicating it was a volcano. Xzavion stood in the middle of the stone battle field. It was a large circle with no bumps. The elevator stopped with a bump, and the doors opened, the outside heat blasting onto them in an instant. They walked out onto the battlefield. The ground was sturdy, and the two of them were ready. The elevator closed and returned to the top, leaving them alone with Xzavion. “Welcome. It’s time to end this once and for all.”

Chapter 5

The Final Showdown

“Welcome to my volcano battlefield!” Xzavion exclaimed.

“Yeah, it looks cool... and it's very hot in here...” Luke said.

“Well, you’ll have to get over that. Now, time to finish you two off...” Xzavion started to hover into the air as he stared at his two oppressors. Tyson gulped as he watched his presentation of power, but Luke silently assured him they would be fine.

Without warning Xzavion started his attacks, starting with tons of more shadow minions. They all rushed towards Luke and Tyson, growling and grunting as they attacked. Luke sliced them one by one and used large shockwaves to take out groups. Tyson shot others with arrows, now using two at a time and shooting multiple targets at once. Xzavion summoned three larger ones, and they each started attacking instantly.

Luke and Tyson each worked on the same one, taking out one after the other. Xzavion summoned more, but after the two had been taking them out with ease, he summoned another with armor. The large cyclops-like being swung at them with its huge hands. Luke rolled out of the way of a swing, the cyclops missing by an inch. Tyson started shooting a single spot, trying to break through the thick armor. As Luke distracted the beast, Tyson continued to shoot, doubling his speed as he got into it.

Finally, an arrow punctured the armor and went into the monster. It turned towards Tyson and rushed at him. Luke quickly ran up from behind and jumped up onto its back. He stabbed the sword into the opening in the armor and killed the cyclops. It fell to the floor with a thud and faded away.

“Fine, I guess I’ll take matters into my own hands,” Xzavion said, lowering closer to the floor. Luke stared at him, ready for any attack. Xzavion burst forward and started swinging at Luke with his fists. He dodged Xzavion’s attacks and started parrying a few with his sword. Xzavion was able to block the blade

without getting cut with his bare arms, as if there was some invisible force blocking it.

Tyson shot an arrow, trying to help Luke. The arrow stabbed into Xzavion's arm but he ripped it out, showing no signs of injury. He continued attacking, soon knocking Luke to the floor with a kick to the stomach. Xzavion tried to keep attacking but Tyson had already jumped in, tackling him to the floor. Luke jumped back up and helped Tyson, keeping him pinned to the floor. Xzavion looked at the two, a smirk on his face.

He teleported behind the two, and they were both pushed a few feet by a large shockwave. They rolled onto the floor but quickly got back up. Luke ran at Xzavion, attacking with his sword again and getting some hits on him. None actually harmed him, but they definitely deteriorated him slowly. Tyson was shooting from afar, getting a few good hits. Xzavion started to blast them with large shockwaves, knocking them closer and closer to the lava.

Luke realized the severity and charged up a large attack. He swung the sword with everything he had. The slash materialized from the blade and flew forward like a

plane, hitting Xzavion and disorienting him severely. He fell onto one knee, taking a quick breather. He stood back up after a few deep breaths, but Luke and Tyson were already back at him. Luke swung at Xzavion, knocking him onto his back.

Tyson pulled his bow back with great force, sending a strong shot into his chest. It sunk deep, and it seemed to actually affect him this time. Luke kept throwing slams with his sword, starting to create a dent in the stone floor as he kept going. Xzavion took the hits for a bit before throwing them both off of him with a shockwave. The two of them were sent into the air and dropped onto the floor hard.

“Well, you’re putting up a good fight so far. I’m impressed. But now I’m done! This is ending now! I’ve only shown you a fraction of my power, and this time... you’re not winning!” Xzavion rose into the air and started charging up an attack. A small ball of energy was formed in Xzavion’s hands and Luke and Tyson backed up, ready for a large attack. A large laser blasted out of his hands, burning the stone that it landed on. He started

moving it towards Luke and Tyson, who quickly started running away from it.

They jumped out of the way as Xzavion flicked it towards them, losing a bit of control over it as it slowly went up. He quickly regained control however. He looked back to Luke and Tyson, who had split up to make it harder for him to hit them. He attacked Luke first, moving the laser towards him. Luke started to run from it, making sure it wouldn't hit him. He dodged it multiple times until Xzavion started to get mad, focusing his attention on Tyson. He moved the laser with haste, immediately sending Tyson into a sprint as he tried to avoid the laser. However, it started to catch up, and he couldn't dodge it much longer.

Luke ran over to him with one last idea that might not work, but he had to try. The laser was inches from Tyson and moving closer. Luke jumped in the way, putting his sword up to block the laser. The sword created some kind of force field causing the laser to wrap around it, keeping the two of them safe underneath. Soon enough Xzavion stopped, knowing he couldn't make it through the shield. The laser dispersed, leaving Luke and

Tyson standing there as Xzavion breathed heavily, staring them down.

Xzavion lowered himself back to the floor, and started to shake the battlefield. The lava started to bubble and rocks started to fall from the roof. Xzavion started to lift parts of the battlefield, throwing large boulders at Luke and Tyson. They dodged some, but then Luke decided to try and slice through one. He swung his sword down on the boulder, cutting it clean in half. Xzavion kept throwing boulders, but to no avail. Luke continued to dodge and slice them, and Xzavion couldn't do much.

He started attacking with more melee combat, punching him and using large shadow weapons to attack with. He swung at Luke with a large hammer, almost crushing him. He then pulled two katanas out of thin air to try and use them to slice him into pieces, but none of them hit him, and Luke was able to get a good hit to his leg, momentarily disabling it. By this time, Xzavion was done and didn't give them a chance.

He started to destroy the battlefield, shaking the volcano and sending ripples through Luke and Tyson's

bodies. Large pillars of rocks fell into the lava, expanding the area they could move around on. Luke and Tyson quickly started to make their way across some rocks, getting far from Xzavion. Some rocks started to form a staircase up to the elevator at about the middle of the volcano. They started to climb; Xzavion was completely unaware as he started to lash out in anger on the surrounding area. The lava started to rise, large splashes flying out and landing on the stone. They finally got to the top. As Luke broke the floor of the elevator, Xzavion noticed their escape attempt. The two climbed out and into the castle area and started running as the building was crashing down on top of them.

Xzavion turned into a huge shadow giant and started chasing the two. He crushed a wall that opened up the castle inside the volcano. However, nothing was behind the wall. He kept destroying them, searching for the two he desperately wanted to stop now. Luke and Tyson were running down hallways, looking for an exit. The walls were collapsing and the roof was falling on top of them, the ground even started to give way at times. They kept going, but the large shakes of

Xzavion's violent attacks to the infrastructure caused lots of stress.

After tons of destruction, Xzavion spotted the two, and focused all his efforts on retrieving them and finishing them off. He reached his hand in at them, crushing any walls in the way. Luke sliced at his large hand, causing him to pull his hand back.

"I found something! Let's go!" Tyson exclaimed. Luke looked over and saw a small hole in the hallway leading out of the volcano and out onto the island. They started sprinting towards it and stopped to look out. The vast ocean stared back at them as they looked out. They stepped onto the grass, the volcano starting to fall apart as Xzavion rose out of the hole in the top, looking around the island for them. He immediately spotted them and climbed out to attack.

Luke dragged Tyson away from where they were, moving into the cover of the trees. Xzavion started throwing large boulders at them. They landed nearby, but couldn't get a direct hit, since Xzavion was unable to see them because of the trees. Luke spotted the cave and told Tyson to follow him into it. They both ran inside, hoping

Xzavion didn't see them. After he seemed to stop throwing rocks, they started talking.

"How the heck do we get out of this?" Tyson asked with urgency in his voice.

"I'm not sure... We have to find something though. We might have to focus on taking him out. We may not be able to do much right now, but we have to try. We can figure out more of a plan later," Luke explained.

"Got it. I guess you're right. It's our only hope now. Let's do this," Tyson said confidently. They each headed out of the cave, getting ready to get up the mountain and attack Xzavion with what they had. He was about five times the size of them, so it was going to be tough to do much damage, but Luke thought that if he could get a powerful enough blow he might be able to end this once and for all.

They each carefully started getting back up the mountain, making sure Xzavion couldn't see them. He was now looking around and demanding them to show themselves. After a few minutes of climbing, Xzavion had been getting restless while Luke and Tyson were

nearing the top of the mountain. They left the cover of the trees, and stood on the edge of the mountain, confronting Xzavion.

He looked at them, enraged with their behavior and yelled, “I’VE HAD IT WITH YOU TWO! PREPARE TO DIE!” He lifted his fist, slamming it down onto the side of the mountain.

Luke and Tyson had already gotten out of the way, and the blow destroyed the outer ring of the volcano top. They ran along it, trying to find a good way to attack Xzavion. Luke looked down into the volcano; the lava was slowly rising, and it looked ready to blow. *We have to get him over the top of it.* Luke thought. He quickly told Tyson his plan. He nodded and they each tried to lure Xzavion over the opening of the volcano. He started to climb up it a bit more; and as they got further from him, he was throwing boulders and trees, picking up anything he could hurl at them.

Luke destroyed them with the shockwaves of his sword and they kept running. Small shadow minions started to appear, blocking their path. Tyson started shooting them from where they were as they ran. Luke

went in, blasting his sword at them, taking out many of them. They got rid of the creatures, meanwhile Xzavion had climbed up to the top of the volcano, not noticing its active state. He dropped his foot down onto the platform that they had fought on before and stood there trying to swat the two. Luke used his sword to block the attacks and Tyson started shooting Xzavion to distract him. He lifted his fist one more time, ready to give a huge blow, but then the volcano started to rumble and shake. Xzavion looked down, realizing the mistake he had made.

The lava burst up and out of the volcano, burning his skin as it flowed up him. He let out a blood-curdling scream as it seared him. The explosion of the volcano caused Luke and Tyson to fly up into the air. Luke felt a moment of weightlessness as he stopped rising about 30 feet above Xzavion. He started falling, ready to strike down his sword with everything he had onto him. He started to glow, a visible aura started to show as he lit up with power. The sword crashed down on Xzavion, causing a large shockwave that cracked the entire island.

Xzavion screamed as he seemed to be sucked into a large rift. The rift started to pull everything in, including Luke and Tyson. They were slowly sucked in, unable to do anything to stop it. Suddenly, everything went black.

Epilogue

Luke woke up in his bed, the soft fur of Leo curled up against him. He sat up and looked around. He had no armor on and there was no sign of the sword. His memory felt a bit funky, the events he just experienced started to become hazy. He wondered what happened to Xzavion, what happened to Tyson, and as it continued to drift away, he wondered if it had all been a dream.

He got up and texted Tyson to check if he was okay. A few minutes later he replied, saying how he was doing fine and how he had had a strange dream. Luke started to question what was going on, but soon lost memory of it. He started to go about his normal life, as if nothing ever happened. He wasn't sure if something like it would ever happen again... but only time would tell. Maybe... just maybe... his story had only just begun.

